SOP-GOV-002 · GitHub collaboration: organisations, teams, issues, discussions, pull requests, projects, Pages

SOP GOV-002 | Status draft | Changed 2026-11-01 | For Stewards and members

Department: GOV · **ID:** 002 · **Status:** draft (approved when tagged) · **Owner:** the organisation's owners (the shop's seat and Chris W); the lab executes · **Last changed:** 2026-11-01

Purpose

One page that says what each GitHub collaboration tool is for in this organisation, who may use it, and how access is decided: by **teams**, with the organisation's **base permission set to No permission**, so that a private repository is read only by the people a team names.

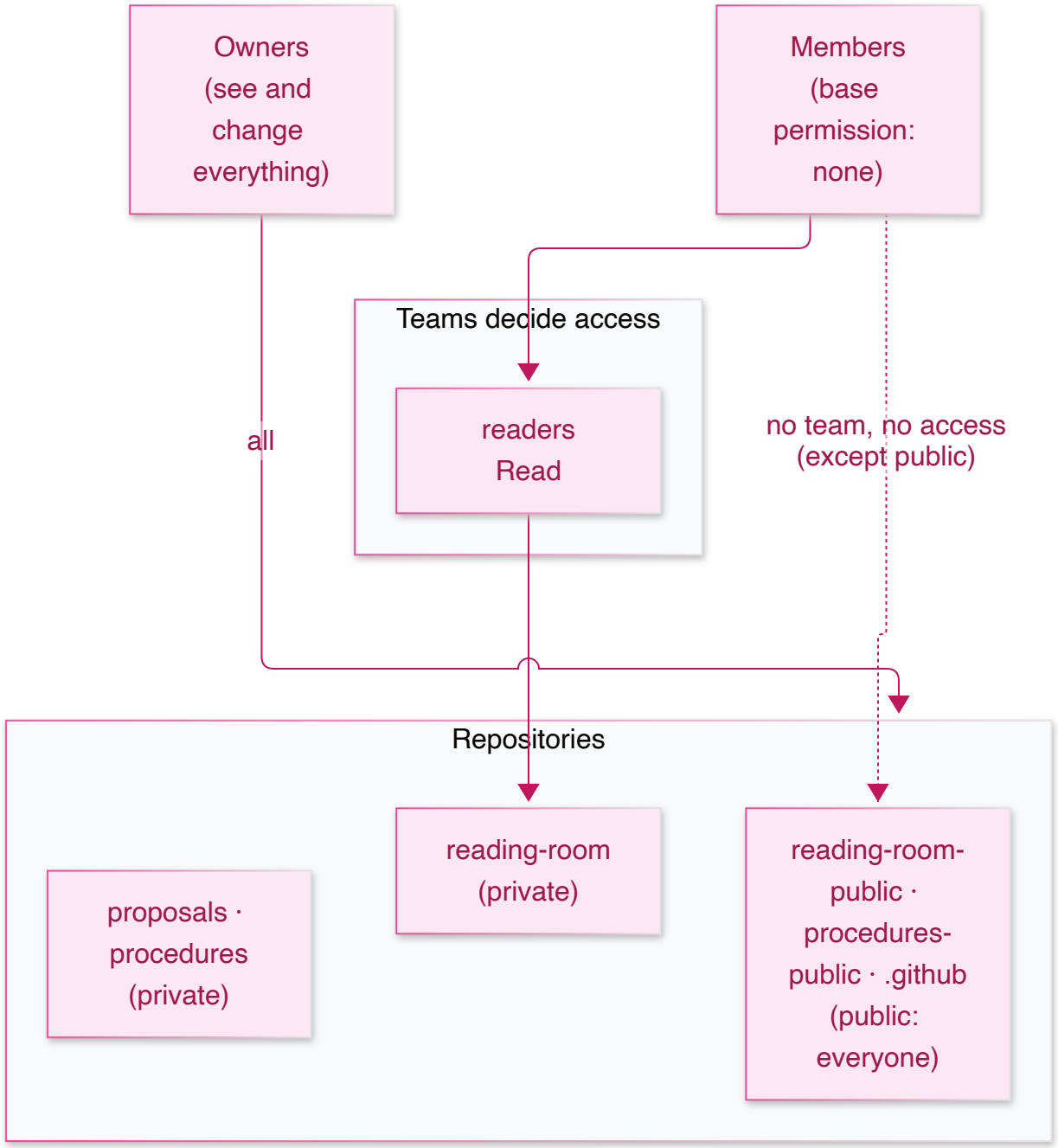
Scope

The organisation's GitHub space: owners, members, outside collaborators, teams, and the tools on each repository. Not credentials (SOP-IT-002), not the road a change travels (SOP-OPS-001/002), not board membership itself (SOP-GOV-001).

Roles

Role	Does
Owner	full control: settings, billing, base permission, teams, invitations. Two or more, so no single person is a point of failure
Member	belongs to the organisation; reads and writes **only** what their teams grant (base permission none)
Team maintainer	adds and removes people in one team, on an officer's yes
Outside collaborator	not a member; granted one repository at a time; use sparingly
Helper	works through a person's own access or an approved connection; opens pull requests, never merges

How access is decided



Base permission: No permission, and why

The **base permission** is what every member gets on every repository before any team is counted. GitHub's default for a new organisation is **Read**: every member can read every private repository. That quietly defeats a readers team or a board team, because a member outside the team can read the repository anyway.

The fleet sets it to **No permission**:

- **Teams become the truth.** A member reads a private repository only through a team that names it; a page that lists a team's repositories lists exactly who can read them.
- **Owners are unaffected.** They keep full access.
- **Public repositories stay public** to everyone, signed in or not.

- ⚠ **Before switching, put every member in a team** that grants what they need. A member in no team loses access to every private repository the moment it changes. Hold the switch for that organisation until they are placed.

> ***Note. Where the heads-up came from.*** *The session's "You should know" reader (SOP-IT-003 describes it) pointed out on 2026-11-01 that the fleet's organisations still had base permission* ***Read****, so the readers and board teams were not actually gating anything for members. The lab steward switched the organisations to* ***No permission*** *the same day, holding one until its member was placed in a team.*

Set it (an owner's action; settings → Member privileges → Base permissions, or):

```
gh api orgs/taylordwraps --jq .default_repository_permission                    # read it first
gh api -X PATCH orgs/taylordwraps -f default_repository_permission=none         # then set it
```

You should see: `none` when you read it again.

At Taylor'd Wraps

- **Owners:** two seats, the shop's and Chris W's, so no single person is the only way in. Until the shop takes its seat, Chris holds the door and nothing waits on the shop.
- **One team,** `readers` **:** Read on `reading-room` only, for anyone the shop names. No board, no committees: a shop needs one door, not five.
- **Base permission** `none` since 2026-11-01 (read from the API that day), so `proposals` and `ops-standard-operating-procedures` are read by the owners alone unless a team is given them.
- **Public:** `.github` (the profile and the welcome deck), `reading-room-public` and `ops-standard-operating-procedures-public`, each written by its sync and the listed pages only (SOP-OPS-003).

The tools, one by one

Tool	Use it for	Who	Notes
Organisation	the house: its people, teams and repositories under one name	owners	free plan; GitHub for Nonprofits gives Team free once incorporation is confirmed
Teams	who reads or writes what: `readers`, `board`, `stewards`, one per committee	owners, team maintainers	**closed** (visible to members) is the default; **secret** only when the team's existence is itself private
Issues	one question, task or decision per thread; "yes / not yet" on a proposal	anyone with Read on the repository	title with the proposal or SOP number; close it when answered
Discussions	open conversation that is not a task: ideas, introductions, Q&A	members, when switched on	switch on per repository (Settings → Features) or for the organisation; move a discussion to an issue when it becomes a task
Pull requests	a change asking to move (`preview` → `main` is a **Promote**)	helpers and members open; a person with the role merges	**merge commit only**, never squash (SOP-OPS-002)

Projects	a board of issues and pull requests across repositories: what is waiting, moving, done	members	optional; a board is a view, the issues stay the truth
Pages	a website from a repository: the public reading room, a site's live and rehearsal lanes	owners switch it on	on the free plan Pages publishes from **public** repositories, and a Pages site is **public**; members-only sites need Enterprise Cloud
The `.github` profile	the organisation's front door: banner, welcome deck, links	owners	public; carries only welcome decks and links

Steps: steward, once per organisation

1. Two owners at least. *You should see:* two names under People → Role: Owner.
2. Create the team (closed): `gh api -X POST orgs/taylordwraps/teams -f name=readers -f privacy=closed`. *You should see:* it on the Teams page.
3. Grant each team its repositories (SOP-GOV-001 and SOP-IT-002 have the commands; `permission=pull` is Read, `push` is Write).
4. Place every member in at least one team. *You should see:* `gh api --paginate orgs/taylordwraps/members --jq '.[].login'` and the union of the teams' members agree.
5. Set the base permission to none (above). *You should see:* `none`.
6. Set merge commits only on the proposals and procedures repositories (SOP-OPS-002). Switch on Discussions where people want them.
7. Ask one member (not an owner) to open one private link they should see and one they should not. *You should see:* the first opens, the second is a 404.

Verification

`gh api orgs/taylordwraps --jq .default_repository_permission` prints `none`; every member is in a team; a member's own test (step 7) matches the teams page.

Troubleshooting

Symptom	Likely cause	What to do
A member suddenly sees 404 on a repository they used to read	base permission switched to none and they are in no team that grants it	add them to the right team; never switch the base back to Read to "fix" one person
A member reads a repository no team grants	base permission is still Read, or they are an outside collaborator on it	read the base permission; check the repository's Collaborators page
Discussions tab missing	not switched on	Settings → Features → Discussions
Pages on a private repository will not switch on	the free plan publishes Pages only from public repositories	publish from the public twin instead (SOP-OPS-003)

Related

- SOP-COM-001 *New to GitHub: your first hour* · SOP-GOV-001 *Who reads the reading room* · SOP-IT-002 *Reading room and helper access*
- SOP-OPS-002 *Pull requests and Promotes* · SOP-OPS-003 *Private houses everything, public lanes witness*
- `my-template/walkthroughs/ORG-SECURITY-SETTINGS.md`, `my-template/NAMES-POLICY.md`

Change log

Date	Change	By
2026-11-01	Drafted: the tools one by one, access by teams, base permission none and why (the "You should know" heads-up)	Alfred
2026-11-01	Adapted for Taylor'd Wraps: two owners (the shop's seat and Chris), one readers team, the public three named, in magenta	Alfred